

WEIRD WORLD

DURING THE FESTIVAL OF CEREALIA, HELD EACH APRIL IN HONOR OF THE GODDESS CERES, FOXES WITH LIGHTED TORCHES TIED TO THEIR TAILS WERE LET LOOSE IN THE CIRCUS MAXIMUS.

tricks—perhaps a tiger licking the hand of its trainer, a team of panthers pulling chariots, or an elephant dancing and walking a tightrope. The crowd thought it was great fun, but killing was what they were really there for—and they soon got it. Some animal shows were little more than blood fests, with wild animals savaging each other to death. Bears fought bulls, bulls charged

at elephants, elephants gored rhinoceroses, and so on. At other times, archers shot arrows at animals from the safety of metal cages—this way, there was little danger of them ending up as animal food.

Massacre in the arena

The highlight of an animal show was when the animal fighters, the *venatores*, and their assistants, the *bestiarii*, entered the arena. Just like gladiators, animal fighters were condemned criminals, prisoners of war, and volunteers, and they received a similar sort of training. Despite their similarity to gladiators, the public regarded animal fighters as inferior beings.

AN ENRAGED BULL AND A FEROCIOUS BEAR FIGHT TO THE DEATH, TORMENTED BY A BESTIARIUS WITH A LONG HOOK.

